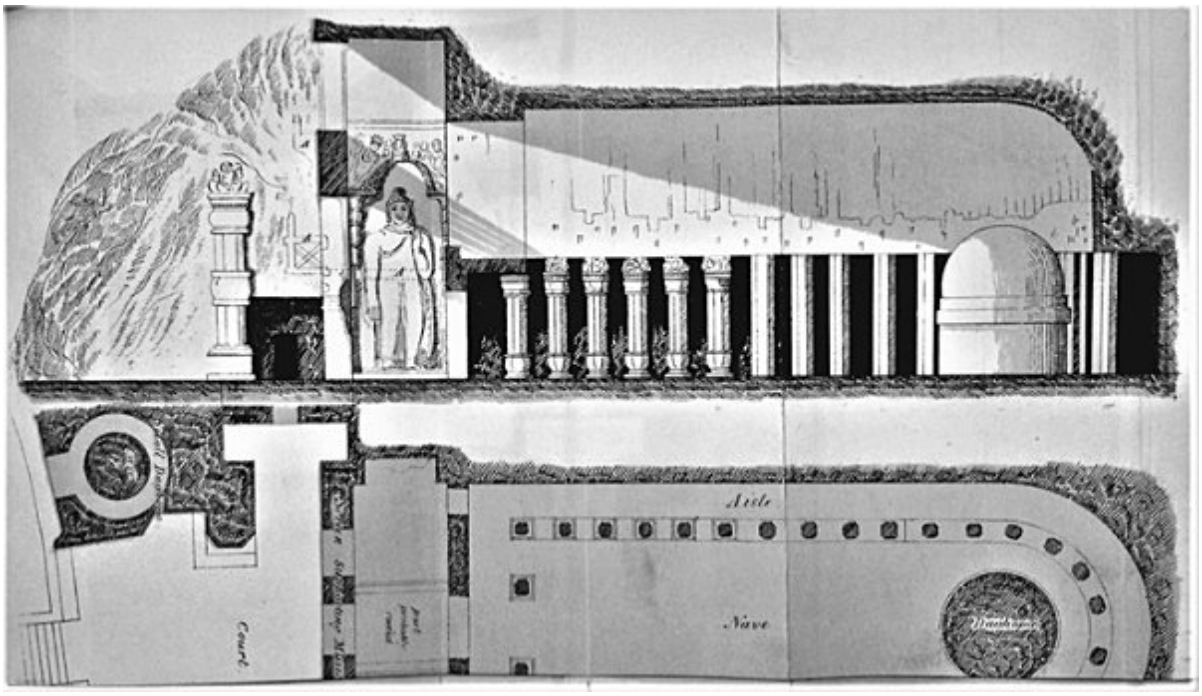


A fold-out from James Fergusson's *Rock-cut Cave Temples of India*, (1842) showing a plan and cross-section of one of the oldest rock-cut caves at Ajanta: Fergusson's Cave 10, an apsidal *chaitya-griha* or prayer-hall begun in the third century BCE under the patronage of the Satavahanas.

Fergusson was puzzled as to why the Hindus had ignored this technique of cutting into rock for so long, only starting in the fifth century CE. Part of the answer was that the Brahmins had no need to retreat into isolated monastic communities and no wish to copy what the heretical faiths were doing; but there was also their ancient Vedic heritage to be taken into account – their ancestral reluctance to build anything solid in the way of temples. Perhaps the earth itself, Prithvi, was still accounted their mother, not to be cut into or built upon. The innate conservatism of religious orthodoxy has also to be taken into account. As so often, it was heterodoxy and its challenging of orthodoxy that brought about change.

More than a quarter of a century after the publication of his *Rock-cut temples* Fergusson joined forces with James Burgess to produce in 1880 a greatly enlarged version of Fergusson's early work as *The cave temples of Western*